

University of Reading Department of Mathematics and Statistics

MA3PPR Individual Report Project Description

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1. Introduction

The third project in this module (Semester 2) will be worth 50% of the module grade (10 credits). Students will be asked to work as an individual to produce a written report on a given mathematical or statistical topic, that is unfamiliar.

Each individual will answer questions posed by the project supervisor (a member of staff). Several individuals will work on essentially the same topic with the same supervisor, but there will be elements that allow each person to make their project distinctive. The expectation is that you will use the literature to help familiarise yourselves with the topic, and then address the questions posed. Some questions may be investigative or require putting your new knowledge to use in other ways.

You will be supported by formal research skills lectures and workshops, as well as supervisions with staff project supervisors. At these supervisions you will be able to discuss your work with your supervisor. **Students will also be expected to carry out independent work outside of the timetabled sessions.**

The **assessed deliverable** will be a technical report. The report is expected to introduce the topic, address the questions, and give a conclusion. The report should “**stand alone**” (the reader should not need to refer to the project description or questions in order to follow it).

2. Report formalities and practicalities

2.1 Report Length and Content

In their report students will be asked to include:

- A declaration statement (AI usage etc) – see Appendix A
- A lay summary – a non-technical summary of their project
- Table of Contents
- List of Tables
- List of Figures
- **Introduction** briefly explaining the context of their project (what is the problem and why is it interesting/important?)
- **Technical content** addressing the questions posed by the project supervisor and any extensions that they choose to include
- **Conclusion** briefly summarizing the key technical message of their findings and its wider implications
- **Reference list**
- **Appendices** – **If you use Generative AI Tools in your project, you must include an AI Appendix.** Some students may wish to include further appendices for code listings etc. Students who do not use Generative AI Tools may not need any Appendix.

Length requirements for MA3PPR students

The total length of the *main body* of the report (from the introduction to the conclusions, excluding front matter, references and appendices) will be a **maximum of 12 sides**. Students will also be able to include **3 further sides** that only contain figures and figure captions. These should be cross-referenced in the main text. Please note that this is a maximum length rather than a target.

MA3PPRNR students (students from NUIST studying in Reading)

In order to satisfy Chinese Ministry of Education requirements, students from NUIST studying in Reading will need to produce a report where the main body is 20 pages long (including figures etc). There is an extra question in the project catalogue for these students, worth 5 marks. Thus the technical content for their project will be marked out of 55 and then rescaled to have the same weighting (50%) in the overall mark for the project.

Font size and margins for all students

Students will be asked to conform to requirements around font size and margins:

- 2.5cm margins
- Minimum font size 11pt

2.2 Report production software and submission

The report can be produced with any software. The students will be provided with

- A LaTeX template and a MS word template
- Information about referencing with LaTeX
- Information about writing a report with MS word
- Information about referencing with word/end-note

Their report will be submitted as a **pdf file** via Blackboard and run through the TurnItIn Plagiarism detection software.

2.3 Generative AI Tools (GAIT)

Students will be allowed to use Generative AI Tools (GAIT) in this assignment in a limited way.

Students **MAY** use GAIT for

- Technical help with computer programming/coding
- Technical help with LaTeX and BibTeX, or equivalently entering mathematical expressions or correctly formatted citations with their chosen software.
- Production of technical visualizations such as graphs, charts and schematics

Students **MAY NOT** use GAIT for any other purpose in this assignment. In particular they **MAY NOT** use GAIT for any writing tasks.

ALL STUDENTS will be asked to **clearly state in their declaration** (see Appendix A) whether or not they used GAIT in their project.

2.4 Acknowledging your use of Generative AI Tools

If you use Generative AI tools to help with your project you need to take three steps to properly acknowledge your use of these tools.

Step 1 clearly state in their Declaration (see Appendix A) whether or not they used GAIT in their project. The Declaration should appear in the front-matter of your project, after the title page.

Step 2 In the main text you should cite your use of GAIT at appropriate points. You can reference this in the format of a personal communication or letter, including the accessed date

e.g.

Citing an AI code generator in-text
(OpenAI ChatGPT, 2025).

Full reference for an AI text generator in your reference list

OpenAI ChatGPT (2025) ChatGPT output on how to code the Z Method to John Smith, 28 March 2025.

Step 3 Provide an AI Appendix explaining more detail.

All students who have used AI should include the following in your AI Appendix

- A description of the AI tool used,
- How the information was generated, including the prompts you used,
- The date accessed,
- Where the material is used in your project,
- How you evaluated the output from the AI tool (to check its correctness).

In addition, if you chose option b in your declaration (i.e. you generated materials that were included within your final assessment in modified form) you **MUST** include the original material generated by GAIT and briefly explain how you modified it.

A suggested format is included in the templates provided for the project.

2.5 Teaching about GAIT

The lectures have covered use of GAIT already (Semester 1 Lecture 6). Students are asked to review this material.

- Introduction to Large Language Models (e.g. ChatGPT is a LLM)
- Tips for using LLMs like ChatGPT and Microsoft Copilot successfully
- Pitfalls/warnings:
 - Personal/sensitive data protection
 - Turning on modes that ensure that your use of these tools is not recorded and used in training
 - Not expecting the output to be correct, sensible and unbiased and therefore needing to critically analyse the output
 - Deskilling (not being able to do it yourself due to over-reliance on these tools)
 - Intellectual property -who owns the Generative AI output?

2.6 Plagiarism

Plagiarism is a serious academic misconduct. The Examination Office defines plagiarism as

“the fraudulent representation of another’s work as one’s own. This applies whatever the source of the material (for example, a published source, the web, or the work of another student), whether the material is copied word for word or paraphrased, and whatever the extent of the material used.”

Instances of plagiarism will be treated as a disciplinary matter and will be referred to the School Director of Teaching and Learning who may impose a penalty or refer the matter to the Senate Standing Committee on Academic Misconduct (SCAM) which has the power to impose more severe

penalties including expulsion from the University. More details can be found here <https://www.reading.ac.uk/exams/policies-and-procedures/academic-misconduct>.

For more information see <https://libguides.reading.ac.uk/study-advice-guides/referencing>

Cases of **poor academic practice** are noted when sections of text are reproduced directly from your references, rather than being written in your own words. Poor academic practice will result in a warning, not a penalty. However, depending on the circumstances, the report might be marked as if the sections in question are absent.

2.7 Late work

There will be LATE submission points for all deliverables that we will open after the deadline. The usual university rules apply to penalties for late submission unless you have extenuating circumstances.

2.8 Disabilities and reasonable adjustments

Some students will have declared disabilities that affect their work. If you have a “green sticker” then please attach it to your work in the front matter so that it does not affect your page count. Markers will take this into account.

If anyone has any questions or concerns they should raise them with the module convenor or their project supervisor.

3. Project choice and allocation

On Blackboard you will find a project catalogue listing the available projects. You should read through them all. You are encouraged to engage with the library and various electronic resources in order to help you make an informed choice.

Please pay special attention to any **project pre-requisites** that may make you ineligible for a project. You will be asked to indicate any projects you are ineligible for on the project choice form.

You will need to enter your choices in a webform, **by the advertised project choice deadline**. If you do not submit the form on time, you will be randomly allocated a project by the module convenor. You will only be able to fill in the form once, so make sure you check your form carefully before submission.

Staff will then allocate you to a group, bearing in mind your preferences. However, some projects may be oversubscribed, so not all students will be able to receive their top choices.

You will not be able to swap projects after project allocation.

4. Project supervisions

Project supervisions will appear in your timetables. These will be updated as soon as possible after project allocation for the students.

- **Semester 2 Week 1 Staff-led project supervision.** In this session, staff should introduce the project, go through the questions and literature suggestions and help the students think about the technical and organisational steps that they need to take in their project.

- **Semester 2 Weeks 3, 5, 7, 8, 10 Student-led project drop-ins.** These are an opportunity for students to ask questions and get feedback from project supervisors. Students should be able to feed in questions in advance via Blackboard “Discussion” tools.
- **Contact outside of scheduled teaching** – Students are requested not to ask questions about their project via email – but to post appropriate questions on the Blackboard discussion board. This helps to ensure equality of treatment for students and ensures that everyone is able to hear the answer and contribute to the conversation. Please use common sense when using the discussion – treat others with kindness and respect and don’t post any personal information.

Appendix A Declaration

Students are expected to include a declaration after the title page of their report. The text of the declaration is included here for students to copy into their project. Please note that you should edit the text that is in square brackets as appropriate for your project. Text this is instructional (in *italics*) can be removed. You only need include statements (a) and (b) if they are appropriate for your project.

Declaration

I certify that this is my own work and that use of material from other sources has been properly and fully acknowledged in the text. I have read the University’s definition of plagiarism and the department’s advice on good academic practice. I understand that the consequence of committing plagiarism, if proven and in the absence of mitigating circumstances may include failure in the Year or Part or removal from the membership of the University. I also certify that neither this piece of work, nor any part of it, has been submitted in connection with another assessment.

In submitting this work I can confirm that I **[have/have not]** used Generative AI Tools to prepare and complete my assignment.

Where you have used Generative AI Tools to prepare and complete work, please edit the text to select one of the following statements:

- a. I acknowledge the use of **[insert AI system(s) and link]** to generate materials to support my research and understanding on the topic when drafting this assignment, but none of the outputs are included in the final version.
- b. I acknowledge the use of **[insert AI system(s) and link]** to generate materials that were included within my final assessment in modified form. I have taken responsibility to ensure that where generated materials are included, these have been referenced appropriately, in accordance with the requirements of the assignment brief.